

When Secular Nationalism Lost Its Audience

Lesson 34 — The rise of political Islam

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain why political Islam gained ground as secular nationalism's appeal declined

2

Trace Hamas's origins from the Muslim Brotherhood's decades of social institution-building

3

Trace Hezbollah's founding as a direct Iranian export following 1979

4

Compare the two movements, and evaluate why each ultimately outcompeted secular rivals

A vacuum secular nationalism could no longer fill

Lesson 33 left Oslo's secular, nationalist peace process collapsing into renewed violence. This lesson explains why an entirely different political vision — rooted in religious rather than secular nationalist identity — was already positioned to fill that vacuum, in Palestine and in Lebanon alike.

A pattern of disappointment, region-wide

Nasser's death, the 1967 defeat, the PLO's limited achievements, and decades of authoritarian rule under secular nationalist regimes left many across the region disillusioned with the ideology that had promised dignity and unity, but delivered neither consistently. Political Islam offered an alternative identity untainted by these specific failures.

The Muslim Brotherhood's patient groundwork in Gaza

Egypt's Muslim Brotherhood, founded in 1928, had maintained an organised presence in Gaza since the 1940s and 1950s. Between 1975 and 1987, a period the Brotherhood itself called “social institution building,” it expanded mosques, schools, and charitable networks dramatically — the number of mosques in Gaza tripled from roughly 200 to 600 between 1967 and 1987 alone, embedding the movement deeply in daily Palestinian life well before it became overtly political.

Hamas, founded 14 December 1987

As the First Intifada erupted, Sheikh Ahmed Yassin and other Brotherhood figures in Gaza founded Hamas — the Islamic Resistance Movement — explicitly to compete with the smaller, more militant Islamic Jihad for Palestinian support, adopting a more overtly nationalist and activist stance than the Brotherhood's earlier, more gradual approach.

Israel's own early, quiet tolerance

In its earliest years, Hamas was discreetly tolerated, and by some accounts indirectly encouraged, by Israeli authorities as a religious counterweight to the secular, more internationally legitimate PLO — a short-term calculation that would look very different in hindsight, once Hamas itself became one of Israel's most determined adversaries.

The 1988 Hamas Charter

Published in August 1988, Hamas's charter called for an Islamic state across the whole of historic Palestine and framed the conflict explicitly in religious rather than purely territorial terms — a significant departure from the PLO's official, secular nationalist charter, which had insisted on separating anti-Zionism from religious framing altogether.

Hezbollah, born from a different revolution's ambitions

While Hamas grew from decades of Brotherhood groundwork, Hezbollah emerged far more suddenly — a direct, deliberate export of Iran's 1979 revolution, formed as Khomeini sought to extend his model of Islamic governance beyond Iran's own borders into the Arab world.

1,500 Revolutionary Guards, and a splintered militia

Following Israel's 1982 invasion of Lebanon, Iran dispatched roughly 1,500 Revolutionary Guard personnel to Lebanon's Beqaa Valley, uniting a breakaway faction of the secular Shia Amal movement — dissatisfied with Amal's willingness to negotiate with the West — into what became Hezbollah, deliberately built as an ideological and military extension of Khomeini's own revolution.

The 1983 Beirut bombings

Attacks attributed to Hezbollah's early network killed 63 people at the US Embassy in April 1983, and 241 American and 58 French personnel in coordinated barracks bombings that October — attacks that directly forced the withdrawal of Western peacekeeping forces from Lebanon, an early demonstration of the group's capacity to reshape great-power policy through force alone.

The 1985 Open Letter

Hezbollah's founding manifesto called for expelling Western influence from Lebanon, the destruction of Israel, and explicit obedience to Khomeini's doctrine of velayat-e faqih — pledging its “leadership, direction, mandate, decisions of war and peace” directly to Iran's Supreme Leader, a level of declared foreign loyalty unusual even among the region's Islamist movements.

Elected representation, without disarmament

From 1992, Hezbollah began contesting and winning seats in Lebanon's parliament, eventually holding cabinet positions from 2005 — all while retaining its own armed wing, becoming, by some assessments, more powerful militarily than Lebanon's own national army. Political participation and armed resistance were never treated as alternatives; Hezbollah pursued both simultaneously.

Israel's withdrawal, May 2000

Israel's unilateral withdrawal from southern Lebanon in May 2000, after eighteen years of occupation, was the first Israeli withdrawal from occupied Arab territory achieved without a negotiated treaty — Hezbollah presented this directly as proof that armed resistance, not diplomacy, had delivered what Oslo-style negotiation had not.

Different origins, a shared basic logic

Hamas grew slowly from decades of grassroots social provision before turning explicitly political; Hezbollah was built rapidly and deliberately as a foreign-sponsored project. Both, however, combined social services, religious legitimacy, and armed resistance into a single package that secular nationalist rivals — the PLO, and Lebanon's own government — struggled to match on any of those three fronts simultaneously.

Services and identity, not just ideology alone

A purely ideological explanation is insufficient: both movements built genuine social infrastructure — clinics, schools, charity — that filled gaps secular authorities left open, earning practical loyalty independent of religious conviction alone. Evaluating their rise means weighing organisational capacity and material provision alongside religious and nationalist appeal, not treating any single factor as sufficient by itself.

A full essay attempt

'The rise of Hamas and Hezbollah owed more to the practical social services they provided than to the religious ideology they proclaimed.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the Brotherhood's social institution-building, and Hezbollah's post-2000 political integration
- Address the counter-argument that ideology and identity mattered just as much as material provision

Key terms from today

Social institution building

The Brotherhood's decades-long expansion of mosques, schools, and charity.

Velayat-e faqih export

Hezbollah's declared obedience to Iran's Supreme Leader.

Hamas Charter, 1988

Framed the conflict explicitly in religious, not only territorial, terms.

Dual-track strategy

Combining electoral politics with retained armed capability.

What to remember

Hamas grew from decades of patient Muslim Brotherhood social institution-building in Gaza, briefly tolerated by Israel as a counterweight to the PLO; Hezbollah was built rapidly as a deliberate Iranian export following 1979. Both combined social provision, religious legitimacy, and armed resistance in ways secular nationalist rivals could not match — and both used specific, concrete achievements, from the intifada to Israel's 2000 withdrawal, to claim vindication for that approach.

Lesson 35 — The 2003 Iraq War and its aftermath

Next lesson: how the September 11 attacks reshaped American policy toward the region, leading to a second, far more consequential war against Saddam Hussein's Iraq.